‘a cadre, which was befuddled, upset and down on morale after the defeats of 2005 and 2009 revived with this. Under Gadkari, for the first time, the party’s way of functioning was broken into smithereens and a brand-new corporate style was constructed. All of us had a hellish time for many, many months. The first thing he broke down was the metaphorical physical resemblance to an old Lutyens’ zone bungalow, which changed and turned into a highly corporate-style functional office of the BJP. That was what emerged.’[102]

Amit Shah’s massive expansion drive between 2014 and 2019 was preceded by an earlier version under Gadkari, which yielded the party a new line of second- and third-rung leadership. ‘In most of the states, Gadkari unleashed the most successful membership campaign for the BJP, and the lakhs of new members that we got in those three years of his presidency just indicated the fantastic relationships that he had been able to form with the state units,’ says another BJP leader.[103] Gadkari also brought in a new generation of party leaders in several states, against the wishes of the old guard. He brought in Harsh Vardhan, Vijendra Gupta and Satish Upadhyaya in Delhi to replace V.K. Malhotra, who had fronted the Delhi unit for decades. Each of them successively became presidents of the Delhi unit. In Maharashtra, he promoted Devendra Fadnavis, who was later handpicked by Modi and Amit Shah to be the state’s chief minster in 2019, and leaders like Vinod Tawde as general secretary. In Madhya Pradesh, he promoted Narendra Singh Tomar and in Rajasthan, Anil Madhav Dave. He also brought into his central team leaders like Dharmendra Pradhan from Odisha as general secretary, J.P. Nadda from Himachal Pradesh and Nirmala Sitharaman as party spokesperson. Each of these leaders went on to hold major ministerial and party roles in the Modi–Shah era.

The recasting of the party—in terms of format, style of functioning and a generational shift—began under Shah’s predecessors. Under Singh and Gadkari, it underwent a major transformation from the organisation that Vajpayee and Advani had built through the 1980s and ’90s. Modi and Shah took that structural transformation to another level after 2014.

In 2014, by the time Rajnath Singh was back for his second stint as party president (2013-14), the party used its now re-